B2 Vocabulary

Easily confused words

Pairs that Arabic speakers often mix up, such as borrow and lend, rob and steal, and say and tell.

Some English words look or feel alike but are used differently. Many of these pairs share one word in Arabic, so they are easy to confuse.

borrow / lend verb

borrow = take for a short time; lend = give for a short time

Can I borrow your car? / Can you lend me your car?

rob / steal verb

rob a person or place; steal a thing

They robbed the bank and stole $10,000.

say / tell verb

say something; tell someone something

He said he was tired. He told me he was tired.

make / do verb

make = create or produce; do = activities and work

make a mistake, make a cake / do homework, do the shopping

bring / take verb

bring = towards the speaker; take = away from the speaker

Bring it here. Take it to the office.

lose / miss verb

lose = no longer have; miss = not catch, or feel sad without

I lost my keys. I missed the bus. I miss my family.

fun / funny adjective

fun = enjoyable; funny = makes you laugh

The party was fun. The comedian was funny.

affect / effect verb / noun

affect is usually the verb; effect is usually the noun

Stress affects sleep. Stress has an effect on sleep.

economic / economical adjective

economic = about the economy; economical = saves money

economic growth / an economical car

sensible / sensitive adjective

sensible = wise; sensitive = easily hurt, or aware of feelings

a sensible decision / sensitive skin

Learn them in a sentence. Memorise a short example such as *Can I borrow your pen?* rather than a translation. The pattern sticks better than the word.

Practice

1. Could you ___ me some money until Friday? (borrow / lend)
2. Someone ___ my wallet on the train. (robbed / stole)
3. She ___ me the meeting was cancelled. (said / told)
4. I always ___ mistakes with prepositions. (make / do)
5. Don't forget to ___ your umbrella when you go out. (bring / take)
6. Buying in bulk is more ___ . (economic / economical)

Teacher page: answers

Print the pages before this one for students.

Answers

1. lend
2. stole
3. told
4. make
5. take
6. economical